In the middle of the innings there was some light drizzle and it turned really dark. My thoughts went back to the South Africa series in January 1997 when rain had denied us victory. This time I was praying for rain and hoping that the match would be washed out, forcing a re-match the next day. We were not so lucky and were eventually all out for 234.

At the presentation it was difficult to watch the Australians celebrate while our own camp was feeling the pain of defeat. When my name was called to collect the Man of the Tournament award for the 673 runs I had scored, it didn't give me much excitement. I am not suggesting that I did not feel honoured or proud, but the feeling was overshadowed by the loss. Now we would have to wait four years before we could have another crack at the World Cup.

In my disappointment, I had not even noticed that the bat I was presented with as the Man of the Tournament was made of gold and I just stuffed it in my kitbag and checked it in as luggage on the way back. Only when people asked to see the bat after we landed in Mumbai did I realize it was gold and had been specially crafted. All I did on the flight back was sleep. Most of the players were still upset and were in no mood to talk. It would take a long time to get over the disappointment.

Looking back, the 2003 World Cup remains a bitter-sweet memory. We played some excellent cricket as a team and I contributed well in almost all of the matches – but not in the final. Beating England and Pakistan were unforgettable high points, but the World Cup trophy was still eluding me.

India in the 2003 World Cup

7th match. India v Netherlands at Paarl. 12 February 2003
India 204 (48.5/50 ov); Netherlands 136 (48.1/50 ov)
India won by 68 runs

11th match. Australia v India at Centurion. 15 February 2003
India 125 (41.4/50 ov); Australia 128–1 (22.2/50 ov)
Australia won by 9 wickets (with 166 balls remaining)

17th match. Zimbabwe v India at Harare. 19 February 2003
India 255–7 (50/50 ov); Zimbabwe 172 (44.4/50 ov)
India won by 83 runs